Zero Respect for Veterans

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SPOTAPOD finds 337 veteran-related posts in LinkedIn engagement-pod files and publishes a guide to fake accounts that impersonate service members

Military consumers reported $584 million in fraud losses to the Federal Trade Commission in 2024.

SPOTAPOD, an open-source, de-identified research project on tracking fake social media accounts, found 337 posts about military veterans in its LinkedIn engagement-pod files, which hold more than 300,000 distinct posts. The project's creator, Daniel Hall, is releasing the counts on Veterans Day with a guide for veterans, families and charities on spotting accounts that copy veterans' names, photos and stories.

The files show veteran-related posts in every year from 2020 to 2026. They do not show that any of those posts or accounts is fake.

What fake socials are

Fake socials are social media accounts, followers or engagement that do not reflect real people acting on their own. The term covers four things:

- **Fake accounts:** profiles run by bots or by people using invented identities, including copied photos of real people.
- **Impersonation:** accounts that use a real person's or organization's name, photo or story, such as the fake service-member and veterans-group accounts described below.
- **Bought or traded engagement:** purchased followers, likes and comments, or pods, which are groups whose members agree to engage with each other's posts.
- **Fake reviews and endorsements:** testimonials written by people who never used the product, or by accounts created for that purpose.

In each case, the numbers (followers, reactions, reviews) look like real audience interest when they are not, and people use them to decide whom to trust, buy from, hire or donate to. Pods are a gray area: the members are usually real people, but the engagement is arranged rather than spontaneous.

What the data shows

The counts come from SPOTAPOD's working files, which draw on five pod and engagement-tool exports; one of them is published as Hall, 2026. Of the 337 posts, 268 are about veterans, 21 mention veterans in passing, and 48 use the word only as a hashtag. The yearly count rose from 1 post in 2020 to 91 in 2024, and 87 posts are dated 2026 so far. In all, 44 posts (13%) are dated within three days of Veterans Day or Memorial Day, which together span 14 days; about 4% would fall there if posts were spread evenly across the year.

The posts come from 101 named accounts, and 15 posts have no account name. One account wrote about a quarter of them, so the counts describe what is in these files and not veterans as a group.

What the data does not show

Engagement pods are groups whose members agree to like and comment on each other's posts. A post's presence in a pod file does not show that the post, its author or its engagement is fake, and this release names no account or person. The counts leave out five duplicate records, count identical text posted on different dates as separate posts, and come from pod and engagement-tool exports, not from a sample of all LinkedIn posts.

Documented ways fake accounts use veterans' identities

- Vietnam Veterans of America (VVA) spent two years, from August 2017 to September 2019, documenting foreign-run pages and accounts that claimed to belong to American veterans, including a "Veterans of Vietnam" page with nearly 160,000 followers and administrators in Russia, Ukraine and Italy. The report also found accounts that copied the VVA name and logo, some used for fraudulent fundraising (VVA investigative report).
- The U.S. Army Criminal Investigation Command warned in May 2019 that criminals copy soldiers' photos and biographies, often with slightly altered names, for romance scams, sales schemes and advance-fee schemes (Army CID notice).
- Meta said in February 2025 that scammers impersonating service members remain widespread. In 2021 the U.S. military in Afghanistan reported nearly 900 fake accounts impersonating Gen. Scott Miller, then its top commander in the country (Stars and Stripes).
- Military consumers filed 99,443 fraud reports with the FTC in 2024, with $584 million in reported losses (FTC Consumer Sentinel Data Book 2024). Veterans and retirees accounted for $419 million of that (AARP). These figures cover all types of fraud, not only impersonation, and the data book is based on unverified consumer reports.

“Veterans are trusted, and that is why their names, photos and stories get copied,” said Daniel Hall, creator of SPOTAPOD and CEO of Dream IT Software. “Our data shows veteran posts in pod files every year since 2020, and it cannot tell us which accounts are real. Impersonating a veteran to take money or trust from someone else shows zero respect for veterans.”

What veterans, families and charities can do

- Search your own name on each platform and run an image search on your profile photos. Scammers copy photos and use the same name with small changes (Army CID notice).
- Report an impersonating profile to the platform at once. Army CID notes that the longer a fake account stays active, the more people it can mislead.
- Report suspected fraud to the VSAFE Fraud Hotline at 833-38V-SAFE (833-388-7233) or at VSAFE.gov, and to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.
- Before giving to a veterans charity found on social media, look it up in the IRS Tax Exempt Organization Search. Fake fundraising accounts have copied the names and logos of real veterans organizations (VVA investigative report).

About SPOTAPOD and Daniel Hall

SPOTAPOD is an open-source, de-identified research project on tracking and exposing fake social media accounts. Project materials are on Harvard Dataverse and GitHub. The veteran-post counts in this release are aggregates from SPOTAPOD's working files; no posts or account names are published.

Daniel Hall is CEO of Dream IT Software, a coauthor of *Top 100 List of Lies on Social Media*, the author of *DIGITAL BOUGHTulism: POONAMI*, a teen field guide to fake social media, and has worked with engagement pods since 2019.

Media contact: Daniel Hall, Dream IT Software

Sources

As of November 11, 2026. SPOTAPOD counts are from the project's working files.

- Vietnam Veterans of America, investigative report, Sept. 17, 2019
- U.S. Army CID, social media impersonation of Soldier accounts, May 28, 2019
- Stars and Stripes, Feb. 13, 2025, on Meta's statement and FTC figures
- FTC Consumer Sentinel Network Data Book 2024
- AARP, FTC report on military scams
- VSAFE.gov, Veterans, Servicemembers, and Families Fraud Evasion
- IRS, charity scams and the Tax Exempt Organization Search, Oct. 15, 2024

Data and project citations

- Hall, Daniel. "LinkedIn posts using fake socials." Harvard Dataverse, 2026. doi:10.7910/DVN/WD9AUR.
- "Replication Data for: SPOTAPOD Analysis Repository." Harvard Dataverse. doi:10.7910/DVN/NT6YM2.
- SPOTAPOD GitHub repository: aggregate-only analysis scripts and outputs; code under MIT, documentation under CC BY 4.0.
- Hall, Daniel. *DIGITAL BOUGHTulism: POONAMI: A Teenagers Field Guide to Fake Social Media*. Amazon.